

The Shocking FAILURE 1

THE STATE SIMPLY SLEPT

It was not a flash flood by a temperamental river but a story of delay and neglect compounded by embankments that had outlived their utility, which led to the disaster

1 AUGUST 5

River Kosi mounts pressure on the spurs at Kusaha, some 12 km upstream in Nepal and begins eroding embankments that ultimately suffer 1 km wide breach.

2 AUGUST 5

Bihar's Chief Engineer E. Satyanarayan stationed at Birpur first alerts state Government's Kosi project liaison officer in Kathmandu, Arun Kumar Singh. Singh on leave, no action taken.

3 AUGUST 9-16

With the situation worsening, Satyanarayan sends telegrams to 11 senior officials associated with flood water management in Patna, warning them against the imminent danger.

4 AUGUST 16

Nepali locals prevent contractor from repairing embankment. Engineers treat labour dispute with local workers as an attack by the Maoists.

5 AUGUST 17

The bulletin of the Bihar irrigation and flood control department claims that all the embankments are safe despite erosion starting.

6 AUGUST 18

Breach in eastern embankment of Kosi. More than 3.7 mn litres of water is discharged through the breach, flood situation steadily deteriorates, inundating hundreds of villages in northern and central Bihar districts.



7 AUGUST 19

Even as breach widens, State Irrigation Minister Bijendra Prasad Yadav (left) takes only routine steps and fails to alert the Centre. Sand bags not stocked in advance while 5 lakh cubic-ft boulders in stock lie unused.

